

All of the planets, all of the time¹

What unites modern ecology, conserving threatened biodiversity, climate dynamics, the nature of early Earth, macroevolution, and the atmospheres of other planets? All fall within the remit of the Earth, Environmental, Ecological, and Space Sciences section, one of the broadest within *Science Advances*. The goal of the 6 deputy editors and almost 60 associate editors within our group is to help our international communities push our science forward by identifying, reviewing, and publishing the most exciting research. We share a dedication to highlighting intriguing new work and ensuring that the peer-review process helps to improve the quality and readability of the work we publish. We are eager to publish new ideas and new voices from around the world and actively seek to expand our pool of reviewers, authors, and editors.

Scientific publishing is a dynamic environment, with many researchers seeking out open-access formats and some questioning whether scientific journals continue to have a role in the dissemination of research. The success of the journal over the past decade suggests that an increasing number of authors find *Science Advances* a valuable, open-access route way to highlight their research for a broad scientific audience. In 2023, the section handled 2699 submissions and published 299 (many of which were submitted in 2022). One of our greatest challenges is that we receive far more interesting submissions than we can send to review. In 2023, about 30% of submissions were selected for review, and, to date, almost 10% of total submissions have been published (with more to come). As the pace of submissions has continued to pick up, we anticipate close to 3300 submissions to our section this year. Climate, ecology, earth sciences, and aspects of microbial studies account for much of the increase in submissions, but we are eager to receive manuscripts across the range of our responsibilities.

Beyond publishing challenging studies of active research questions, we are always seeking work that asks

new questions and provides insights from new data. And just because we have not published work in an area does not mean we are not interested—we may not have had good submissions. To advance our goal of highlighting the research areas we serve, we are planning to increase the number of review articles and special issues invited by the editors. While the number of these will always be small, we hope to use such invitations to highlight new insights into problems of broad relevance.

After the initial triage of submissions by deputy editors to find the most interesting and exciting possibilities, we rely on our associate editors for further vetting and handling the review process. An advantage of journals such as *Science Advances* and other society journals is that the editors are all practicing scientists, and we have all had papers declined.

Evaluating the flow of submissions would be impossible without the skill and dedication of the associate editors. New editors quickly learn the unavoidable reality that manuscripts may not be reviewed for reasons that have little to do with the quality of the research. We may have recently published similar work, or a pulse of submissions may have limited the number of available associate editors. Occasionally editors may solicit 10 to 12 reviewers without positive responses and must regretfully conclude that a manuscript might find a more appropriate home elsewhere.

The payback for serving as a deputy or associate editor is the opportunity for a first look at new work, learning more about a global community of researchers, and playing a small part in presenting some of the most exciting new work in our fields to a broader scientific audience.

—Doug Erwin

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¹With apologies to the NASA Planetary Protection Office when under the leadership of John Rummel.